

Owen Liss, Hudson Michell-Pullman
Delegation From Allied Gardens, San Diego
The Republic of Latvia
United Nations Children's Fund
Literacy Education For Children

I. Topic Background

Literacy education is an exponentially important part of a child's development and dictates everything from a child's mental health to schooling and job opportunities, and although Latvia does not have issues with this (Latvia's literacy rate is 99.89%¹), surrounding countries do. Countries that struggle with lower literacy rates and levels of literacy are likely to deal with higher crime rates, lowered workforce productivity leading to a massive loss in tax revenue, and a higher risk of mental health issues which end up costing trillions of dollars globally.² Parents with below-average literacy levels have 72% of children with literacy issues.³ In addition, children and parents who have low literacy levels have higher hospitalization rates due to the lack of engagement and adherence to health services and medical advice such as cancer and other disease screening.⁴ Multiple studies have consistently revealed links between literacy and infant mortality rates because of malnutrition and lack of proper vaccination.⁵ In 1999, studies

¹ *Latvia Adult Literacy Rate, 1960-2022 Knoema*,
[https://knoema.com/atlas/Latvia/topics/Education/Literacy/Adult-literacy-rate#:~:text=Latvia%20%2D%20Adult%20\(15%2B\)%20literacy%20rate&text=Adult%20literacy%20rate%20of%20Latvia,average%20annual%20rate%20of%200.11%25](https://knoema.com/atlas/Latvia/topics/Education/Literacy/Adult-literacy-rate#:~:text=Latvia%20%2D%20Adult%20(15%2B)%20literacy%20rate&text=Adult%20literacy%20rate%20of%20Latvia,average%20annual%20rate%20of%200.11%25).

² Tasha Swearingen, *The Cost of Low Literacy to the Nation*, December, 18, 2021,
<https://www.homeschool.com/blog/2018/04/the-cost-of-low-literacy-to-the-nation/>.

³ *The impact of illiteracy and the importance of early Intervention*, May, 12, 2022,
<https://worldliteracyfoundation.org/early-intervention-reduces-illiteracy/#:~:text=Social%20Impact,and%20 higher%20 levels%20of%20 crime>.

⁴ *The impact of illiteracy and the importance of early Intervention*, May, 12, 2022,
<https://worldliteracyfoundation.org/early-intervention-reduces-illiteracy/#:~:text=Social%20Impact,and%20 higher%20 levels%20of%20 crime>.

⁵ Olivia Giovetti, *6 benefits of literacy in the Fight against poverty*, August, 27, 2020,
<https://www.concernusa.org/story/benefits-of-literacy-against-poverty/#:~:text=Literacy%20promotes%20%E2%80%9C lifelong%20learning%E2%80%9D%20and%20 builds%20 skills&text=Literacy%20and%20 numeracy%20 are%20 a,can%20 complete%20 a%20 basic%20 education>.

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conducted in Bolivia and other areas in South America show that parents who participated in programs run by Save The Children were less likely to bear the effects of malnutrition.⁶ Literacy education is even more essential at young ages since it paves the way to more learning which leads to better adaptability to our quickly changing world.⁷ Children who are born between 1979 and 1989 and struggle with language barriers in the classroom are almost four times as likely to drop out of high school without receiving their diploma.⁸ Possessing the ability to read is just as crucial as having functional literacy which is having the literacy adroitness required for day-to-day life which is a necessity for current society.⁹ Today more than ever, literacy plays an exceedingly important role in our society because of the many technological advancements that require critical thinking and top-level literary skill to comprehend.

As previously stated, Latvia has had little struggle with literacy rates and holds the highest in Europe at 99.98%. Although Latvia and many of its surrounding countries boast a high literacy rate, literacy rates are only sometimes an accurate representation of literacy since they do

⁶ *Do multi-sectoral development programmes affect health? A Bolivian case study*, <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/10787656/>.

⁷ Christopher Cocchiarella, *What is Functional Literacy, and why does our high-tech society need it?*, May 30, 2021, <https://mindfultechnics.com/what-is-functional-literacy/>.

⁸ Olivia Giovetti, *6 benefits of literacy in the fight against poverty*, July 14, 2022, <https://www.concernusa.org/story/benefits-of-literacy-against-poverty/#:~:text=Literacy%20promotes%20%E2%80%9C lifelong%20learning%E2%80%9D%20and%20builds%20skills&text=Literacy%20and%20numeracy%20are%20a,can%20complete%20a%20basic%20education>

⁹ Olivia Giovetti, *6 benefits of literacy in the Fight against poverty*, August, 27, 2020, <https://www.concernusa.org/story/benefits-of-literacy-against-poverty/#:~:text=Literacy%20promotes%20%E2%80%9C lifelong%20learning%E2%80%9D%20and%20builds%20skills&text=Literacy%20and%20numeracy%20are%20a,can%20complete%20a%20basic%20education>.

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not take into account the levels of literacy.¹⁰ In Latvia and Lithuania, a study was conducted using the 47-item European Health Literacy Questionnaire (HLS-EU-Q), a survey with questions in the domains of health care, disease prevention, and health promotion. The results showed that throughout rural and Urban areas of Latvia, 79% of Latvians have a below-average health literacy levels and 73% of Lithuanians possess inadequate health literacy.¹¹ Low health Literacy can cause misinterpretation of drug dosage leading to higher hospitalization as well as an increased likelihood of disease development that causes higher mortality rates. This low health literacy rate is a substantial factor that leads 9.1% of Latvians to be long-term drug injectors or regular users of drugs such as opioids and amphetamines.¹² In 2012 there were 170 known drug-induced deaths in Estonian which is up from 101 from two years earlier.¹³ Children living with ill parents are likely to experience social-emotional and behavioral issues that can lead to issues around education such as chronic absence.¹⁴ As of 2012, 23.4% of Latvians under the age of 17 are living under the poverty line whereas only 18.8% of adults up to the age of 64 are

¹⁰ Christopher Cocchiarella, *What is Functional Literacy, and why does our high-tech society need it?*, May 30, 2021, <https://mindfultechinics.com/what-is-functional-literacy/>.

¹¹ *Level of health literacy in Latvia and Lithuania: a population-based study*, July, 11, 2022, <https://archpublichealth.biomedcentral.com/articles/10.1186/s13690-022-00886-3>.

¹² Chris Harris, Italy, *Latvia and UK among Europe's worst for serious drug use, says report*, May, 6, 2014, <https://www.euronews.com/2014/06/05/italy-latvia-and-uk-among-europes-worst-for-serious-drug-use-says-report>.

¹³ Chris Harris, Italy, *Latvia and UK among Europe's worst for serious drug use, says report*, May, 6, 2014, <https://www.euronews.com/2014/06/05/italy-latvia-and-uk-among-europes-worst-for-serious-drug-use-says-report>.

¹⁴ *Parental Chronic Illness, Internalizing Problems in Young Adulthood and the Mediating Role of Adolescent Attachment to Parents: A Prospective Cohort Study*, December, 31, 2021, [https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC8758574/#:~:text=Many%20more%20studies%20have%20indicated,illness%20\(5%2C%2010\)](https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC8758574/#:~:text=Many%20more%20studies%20have%20indicated,illness%20(5%2C%2010).).

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under.¹⁵ With such a large number of children living in poverty, receiving a quality education is of the utmost importance. Latvia has already seen a decrease in poverty from 2008 to 2012 as the poverty rate dropped from 26.3% which seems to be due mostly to the fact that primary as well as secondary education became free and obligatory.¹⁶ The main reason that the poverty rates still continue to lie at such a high rate is mainly due to discrimination in the Latvian education system.¹⁷ Romani and Russian speakers are victims of major language barriers since most Latvian schools do not offer to teach in these languages. Additionally, there is sort of a “separate but equal society” where Romani and some Russian children are forced to attend different classes than their fellow students which reinforces the belief that they are not capable of sharing education with their Latvian peers. The European Commission Against Racism and Intolerance (ICRI) has decided to work on the issues and has promised that the Latvian education system will change its curriculum to include instruction in minority languages as well as fight to end the separation of ethnicities in classes.

II. Country Policy

The Baltic States are home to some of the highest literacy rates globally with an average of 99.86% which far exceeds the 96% that the United Nations Educational Scientific and

¹⁵ Brianna White, *Education in Latvia: An End to Discrimination*, November, 3, 2017, <https://borgenproject.org/education-in-latvia-an-end-to-discrimination/>.

¹⁶ Brianna White, *Education in Latvia: An End to Discrimination*, November, 3, 2017, <https://borgenproject.org/education-in-latvia-an-end-to-discrimination/>.

¹⁷ Brianna White, *Education in Latvia: An End to Discrimination*, November, 3, 2017, <https://borgenproject.org/education-in-latvia-an-end-to-discrimination/>.most

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Cultural Organization (UNESCO) considers a “high literacy rate”. Latvia values literacy and education as essential tools for daily life, 90% of Latvian adults have completed a secondary education which is much higher than the average European country. For reference, The Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) average is 75% and the Group of Twenty (G20) average is 60%.¹⁸ Latvia’s main way of testing for literacy is the OECD Programme for International Student Assessment (PISA), anything around the OECD average score of 487 is considered an adequate literacy level, and anything above that is considered exceptional. Latvia in addition to other Baltic states does have struggles with discrimination in the education system against minority ethnicities such as Russians, Belarussians, Polish, and Ukrainians.¹⁹ Only 40 percent of Latvian primary schools offer to teach Russian which does not line up since 24% of the Latvian population speak Russian.²⁰ The Latvian government is working to vote through legislation to raise this number in the coming years which the government thinks will help improve end-of-high-school exam results that are only given in Latvian, a language that shares very little with Russian.²¹ Latvia has decided to set aside 3.3 million pounds (3.82 million U.S. dollars) from European Union (EU) structural funds to help at least 2,700 teachers improve

¹⁸ Pezemyslaw Bociaga, *Baltic States Have the Highest Literacy Rates in the World*, January, 17, 2023, <https://3seaseurope.com/baltic-states-have-the-highest-literacy-rates-in-the-world/>.

¹⁹ *Latvia’s school language reform irks Russian minority*, June 24, 2018, <https://www.euractiv.com/section/languages-culture/news/in-latvia-school-language-reform-irks-russian-minority/>.

²⁰ *Latvia’s school language reform irks Russian minority*, June 24, 2018, <https://www.euractiv.com/section/languages-culture/news/in-latvia-school-language-reform-irks-russian-minority/>.

²¹ *Latvia’s school language reform irks Russian minority*, June 24, 2018, <https://www.euractiv.com/section/languages-culture/news/in-latvia-school-language-reform-irks-russian-minority/>.

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their language skills. Although this seems to be quite a large quantity of money, the Delfi.lv writes that as many as 8000 teachers would need to improve their Latvian language which might make the money inadequate. Additionally, Both Lithuania and Latvia hope to increase their media literacy level by adding explicit mentions of media and information literacy into their general School curriculum. This addition of curriculum regarding critical analysis of media content is expected to “reduce one-direction influence of mass media communication allowing to identify and prevent the distribution of biased information”.²² Lithuania whose media literacy level was tested for the first time in 2017 and had a level of 37.8 percent and hoped to raise that to 41.3 percent by the year 2023.²³ With the Baltic region having some of the best literacy rates worldwide, it is easy to see how much value they find in literacy education, Latvia, although having an outstanding literacy rate still has issues in its education system that they hope to end in the coming years.

III. Proposed Solutions

The Latvian constitution (Satversme) which was adopted in 1922 prescribed that everyone has the right to education. Latvia ensures that every child may acquire integrated primary education and lower secondary education free of charge. The main aim of the education policy in Latvia is “to provide quality educational opportunities for all residents of Latvia to

²² *Media Literacy in the Baltics: Different Approaches in Neighboring Countries*, December, 6th, 2020, <https://media-and-learning.eu>.

²³ *Media Literacy in the Baltics: Different Approaches in Neighboring Countries*, December, 6th, 2020, <https://media-and-learning.eu>.

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promote the development and realization of their potential throughout their lives and to develop their ability to change and manage the constant changes in society and economy”.²⁴

Latvia provides a legal entitlement to early childhood education and care (ECEC) for all children past the age of 18 months. Municipalities are obligated to ensure that any Latvian citizen has access to an ECEC station close to their home. As stated previously, Latvia has issues with discrimination of minorities in the educational system and scores below the OECD average in reading. In recent years Latvia has increased its total general government expenditure on education (% of GDP) from 4.2% in 2018 to 6% as of 2020.²⁵ The Latvian teacher salaries have had massive increases in recent years because of this increase in expenditure, from 2015 to 2021 Latvia increased its teacher salaries by an exponential 59%.²⁶ Still, Latvia's teacher salaries are still relatively low at an average of 29,169 USD compared to the 50,026 of the OECD countries.

²⁷ Although this jump in salaries might seem minuscule, it is still a leap towards helping better minor education issues that Latvia is facing. In 2018, the Latvian Parliament approved amendments to the Education Law and the Law on General Education that

²⁴ Eurydice Latvia, <https://eurydice.eacea.ec.europa.eu.Q>.

²⁵ *Education at a Glance 2022: OECD Indicators*, <https://www.oecd-ilibrary.org/sites/90f24437-en/index.html?itemId=/content/component/90f24437-en>.

²⁶ *Education at a Glance 2022: OECD Indicators*, <https://www.oecd-ilibrary.org/sites/90f24437-en/index.html?itemId=/content/component/90f24437-en>.

²⁷ *Education at a Glance 2022: OECD Indicators*, <https://www.oecd-ilibrary.org/sites/90f24437-en/index.html?itemId=/content/component/90f24437-en>.

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works towards a gradual transition to a mostly Latvian secondary education. Starting in the 2022-2023 school year, all general education subjects in upper-secondary programs will be taught only in the Latvian language excluding foreign language classes.

The Delegation of Latvia believes that bilingual teachers or teachers with knowledge of a second language should be hired, as of 2018 only 60 percent of schools in Latvia were taught in the Latvian language leaving 40 percent of schools being taught in minority languages like Russian.²⁸ This becomes a major issue with end-of-high school exams because they are only given in Latvian which causes half of Latvia's students to struggle with the exams. By hiring bilingual teachers and putting money into training to speak across different languages, Latvia can help transition the many minority language schools to having more of their general education material in Latvian to help break the language barrier that is causing discrimination in the education system. The Latvian school districts can do this by offering benefits for teachers who have taken their own time to learn and educate themselves on a second language. Greater health benefits that cover a wider range of issues are big motivational factors for almost any type of job. In a study done by Fractl in 2016, over 90% of employees would rather take a low-paying job with higher-quality health benefits than a higher-paying job with a lack of health benefits.²⁹

²⁸ Daiva Repeckaite, *Latvia tries to boost majority language in schools*, September, 8, 2018, <https://www.dw.com/en/latvia-pushes-majority-language-in-schools-leaving-parents-miffed/a-45385830>.

²⁹ Jeffry Smith, *How compensation and benefits can motivate employees*, August, 17, 2021, <https://www.hrreporter.com/focus-areas/compensation-and-benefits/how-compensation-and-benefits-can-motivate-employees/358978>.

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Bilingualism is additionally linked with many positive effects such as having better creativity and flexibility as well as being more open-minded to ideas which are essential traits for any teacher.

Latvia can also raise awareness of Latvian citizens' legal entitlement to ECEC for any children past the age of 18 months. The delegation of Latvia believes that raising awareness of their ECEC programs will help improve children's Latvian literacy levels in future years. If children start to begin to learn and be introduced to the Latvian language at a young age, they will need less exposure to it in primary and secondary education which helps prevent the problem of language barrier discrimination before it even has time to start. Learning a language at a young age is proven to have many benefits such as greater confidence, higher and more advanced reading skills in primary and secondary education, and higher test and exam results.³⁰ This will help improve the Latvian reading test levels where they score below the OECD average on. Learning a language at an earlier age also allows more future job opportunities which allows for a stronger economy and more money to be put towards helping better the Latvian education system. We believe if these strategies are implemented in the Latvian community, there will be advances in the fight against discrimination and language issues in the Latvian education system.

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³⁰ *Top 10 Benefits of Learning a Second Language at an Early Age*,
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